

STORYLINE STORYBOARD — AS BUILT

Keep Your Cool: A Customer De-Escalation Simulation

12 Slides | Articulate Storyline 360 | July 2026 | Trina

Reflects the actual final Storyline 360 build, including debugging and design changes made during development. This section documents what was actually built; where the build deviated from the original plan, it's called out explicitly.

Storyboard — As Built

This section documents what was actually built, including every change from the original plan. Where the build deviated from the original storyboard, it's called out explicitly.

Slide 1: Welcome & Mission Briefing

As Built	Navy/white/teal layout as planned, built with shapes instead of the icon library (flat ovals) — a fine substitution. Player Next/Prev/Menu navigation disabled globally so learners can only move via in-slide buttons.
Key Triggers	On Timeline Start: Score=0, EmpathyShown=False, DragDropAttempts=0, ConsequencePathVisited=False. Start Simulation button → Jump to Slide 2.
Deviation from Original Plan	None from plan, beyond using shapes instead of icons.

Slide 2: Meet Sam — Scenario Context

As Built	Hotspot ('What am I noticing?') made optional by design, not a gate — confirmed and kept intentionally after review. A short instructional nudge ('Click to see what stands out') was added beneath the hotspot label to improve discoverability without forcing interaction. The base-layer Continue button was deliberately preserved so learners who skip the hotspot are never blocked.
Key Triggers	Hotspot Click → Show Layer 'Cues Revealed'. Continue (base layer or Cues layer) → Jump to Slide 3.
Deviation from Original Plan	Considered removing the base-layer Continue to force exploration, then reversed that decision — forcing it would have turned an optional scaffold into a hard gate, contradicting the original low-stakes design intent for this slide.

Slide 3: Decision Point 1 — Read the Room

As Built	Correct answer remains in slot B. Two coaching layers ('Too Procedural' for A, 'Dismissive' for C) with unlimited Try Again retries. No severe/bypass branch on this slide — every path
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	eventually reaches the correct answer.
Key Triggers	Option B → Score +10, EmpathyShown=True, Jump to Slide 4. Options A/C → Score adjustment removed from Try Again (see Known Issues below) → Show respective coaching layer. Try Again → Hide layer.
Deviation from Original Plan	Originally scored -5 for poor choices; simplified to 0-point wrong answers (no negative marking) once a scoring bug surfaced during testing (see Case Study reflection).

Slide 4: Sam Responds — Momentum Check

As Built	Built exactly as planned — linear transition, no logic changes.
Key Triggers	Continue → Jump to Slide 5.
Deviation from Original Plan	None.

Slide 5: Decision Point 2 — Choose Your Technique

As Built	Correct answer remains in slot B. Option A is a recoverable miss (same-slide coaching + retry). Option C is the 'severe' deflecting choice and routes to Slide 8 instead of a same-slide layer — this is one of only two decisions in the whole simulation capable of costing points outright rather than being retried into a correct answer.
Key Triggers	Option B → Score +10, Jump to Slide 6. Option A → Show Layer 'Coaching — Jumped to Solution'. Option C → ConsequencePathVisited=True, Jump to Slide 8 (no points awarded).
Deviation from Original Plan	None — built as originally planned.

Slide 6: Drag-and-Drop — Match the Technique

As Built	Built as a native Storyline Freeform Drag-and-Drop question. Column headers ('Customer Statements' / 'De-escalation Techniques') added for clarity. Shuffle set to 'Answers' (randomizes drag item order each load). Attempts set to Unlimited. Drop Target Options: only one item allowed per target, items return to start if dropped outside a target. A manual DragDropAttempts +1 trigger was added to the Submit button, positioned above the built-in Submit/evaluate trigger. The native question's own point value was set to 0 for Correct, since Storyline's built-in quiz scoring was found to be silently adding points into the custom Score variable during testing (see Case Study) — this was the actual root cause of a hard-to-trace scoring bug.
Key Triggers	Submit → DragDropAttempts +1 → Submit Drag and Drop

Deviation from Original Plan

(evaluate). Correct result → Show 'Correct' layer → Continue → Jump to Slide 7. Incorrect/Try Again result → Show 'Try Again' layer → Retry → Reset Results → Hide layer.

Used Storyline's auto-generated Correct/Incorrect/Try Again layers instead of custom-built ones — functionally equivalent and faster to build. Native quiz point value zeroed out to prevent double-scoring.

Slide 7: Decision Point 3 — Lead With Empathy

As Built

Answer position deliberately shuffled: the correct, empathetic response was moved to slot C, and the dismissive 'these things happen' line was moved to slot B (as the severe/deflecting option routing to Slide 8). Slot A remains the 'too clinical' recoverable miss. This was a deliberate anti-pattern-matching decision so the correct answer isn't always in the same slot across the simulation.

Key Triggers

Option C → Score +10, EmpathyShown=True, Jump to Slide 9.
Option B → ConsequencePathVisited=True, Jump to Slide 8 (no points). Option A → Show Layer 'Coaching — Too Clinical'.

Deviation from Original Plan

Original plan had the correct answer in slot B on every decision slide; this was corrected specifically on Slide 7 to reduce predictability.

Slide 8: Consequence Branch — When Communication Breaks Down

As Built

Built as planned — a shared landing slide reachable from either Slide 5's Option C or Slide 7's Option B, both of which represent the 'severe' deflecting/minimizing response pattern. Rejoins the main path at Slide 9 regardless of which slide it was entered from.

Key Triggers

Continue → Jump to Slide 9.

Deviation from Original Plan

None.

Slide 9: Decision Point 4 — Resolve the Issue

As Built

Answer position shuffled: the correct answer was moved to slot A (originally planned as slot B). Slots B and C are both recoverable same-slide misses with coaching layers and unlimited retry — there is no severe/bypass path on this slide, meaning it always eventually contributes its full +10 to the final score.

Key Triggers

Option A → Score +10, Jump to Slide 10. Options B/C → Show respective coaching layer ('Vague Follow-up' / 'Underselling the Fix') → Try Again → Hide layer.

Deviation from Original Plan

Answer slot changed from B to A as part of the anti-pattern-matching pass.

Slide 10: Resolution — Sam's Final Reply

As Built	Built exactly as planned — linear closing transition before Results.
Key Triggers	Continue — Jump to Slide 11.
Deviation from Original Plan	None.

Slide 11: Your Results

As Built	Score display changed from '/100' to '/40' to match the real point ceiling once negative marking was removed (four decisions × 10 points each, drag-and-drop carries no separate score). Pass threshold changed from 70 to 30. A three-tier ring system was built (Red 10–14 / Yellow 15–29 / Green 30+), but because Slides 3 and 9 always eventually award their +10 (no severe/bypass option on either), the true achievable score range is only 20, 30, or 40 — the Red/Low ring is mathematically unreachable in the current design. This was identified during testing and intentionally left as-is (documented limitation) rather than reworked, since it does not affect the accuracy or usefulness of the feedback the learner actually receives. Review Key Techniques and Retry Simulation buttons live on the base layer so they remain accessible under any conditional feedback layer.
Key Triggers	On Timeline Start (conditional): Score≥30 — Show Pass Message; Score<30 — Show Retry Recommended; EmpathyShown=False — Show Empathy Note. Ring visibility triggers keyed to the same 15/30 thresholds. Retry Simulation — Jump to Slide 1 (re-fires the variable-reset triggers). Review Key Techniques — Jump to Slide 12.
Deviation from Original Plan	Score ceiling, pass threshold, and ring tiers all recalculated from the original /100 plan down to the real /40 ceiling. Low/Red ring is unreachable by design and left as a known, low-impact limitation.

Slide 12: Key Takeaways & Job Aid

As Built	Built as planned. The closing button was wired to Storyline's native 'Exit course' action rather than looping back to Slide 1 — consistent with how the two prior Storyline portfolio projects (phishing awareness, Google Classroom) were closed out, and a more appropriate signal of a deliberate ending for a portfolio piece.
Key Triggers	End Simulation — Exit course.
Deviation from Original Plan	Closing action changed from 'Jump to Slide 1' to 'Exit course.'

Variable Table — As Built

Variable	Type	Initial	Notes
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Score	Number	0	+10 per correct decision across the 4 decision slides (max 40). No negative marking — incorrect selections on recoverable slides simply retry at 0 cost; the two severe/deflecting options (Slide 5-C, Slide 7-B) award 0 and route to the consequence branch instead of retrying.
EmpathyShown	True/ False	False	Set True on the first empathetic correct answer (Slide 3-B, 7-C). Drives the Empathy Note layer on Slide 11 if never triggered.
DragDropAttempts	Number	0	+1 per Submit click on Slide 6. Drives the first-try vs. multi-try message on the Correct layer.
ConsequencePathVisited	True/ False	False	Set True when the learner takes the severe/deflecting path on Slide 5 or Slide 7 and lands on Slide 8.

Known Limitations (Documented, Not Hidden)

A short, honest account of the trade-offs made during development — useful both as QA documentation and as interview talking points.

- Achievable final scores are 20, 30, or 40 out of 40 — 0 and 10 are mathematically unreachable, because two of the four decisions (Slides 3 and 9) always resolve to a correct answer through unlimited retry, while only the other two (Slides 5 and 7) can genuinely cost points. As a direct result, the Low/Red results ring can never display. This was identified during QA and deliberately left in place rather than reworked, since the feedback learners actually receive (pass/retry, ring, empathy note) remains accurate and meaningful across every real outcome.
- Storyline's native Freeform Drag-and-Drop question includes its own built-in point-scoring system, separate from the project's custom Score variable. Early builds left the native question's Correct-answer point value at its default (10), which silently added extra points into the custom Score variable alongside the intended manual triggers, producing a scoring bug that took a full trigger-by-trigger and Variables-panel audit to isolate. The native point value is now set to 0 so all scoring runs exclusively through the custom variable.
- The 'Empathy Note' layer on Slide 11 (shown when EmpathyShown = False) can never actually display, for the same structural reason as the unreachable Low ring: EmpathyShown is set to True on Slide 3's Option B, and Slide 3 has no severe/bypass path, so every learner is forced to retry until they select that option before they can advance at all. EmpathyShown is therefore guaranteed True for every learner by Slide 11, making both the variable and its dependent layer functionally dead weight. This was identified after publishing; the layer and its trigger were intentionally left in the file

rather than removed, since it has no effect on the learner experience and reworking it would require changing Slide 3's branching design.

- The results screen's progress ring is a 3-tier, discrete-state visual (not a true proportionally-animated fill), which is an appropriate simplification for Storyline 360's trial version and a beginner build timeframe.

End of Storyboard — Keep Your Cool: A Customer De-Escalation Simulation | Portfolio Project